

Chapter

The Secret of the Shivling — Awakening the Shiva and Shakti Within



Introduction: A Question for Maha Shivratri

On Maha Shivratri, millions of people perform abhishek on the Shivling and offer bilva leaves. But what does the thing we worship actually mean? In this chapter, Acharya Upendra Ji puts exactly this question before us:

"You worshipped the Shivling, so whom did you actually worship? Today we are performing abhishek on the Shivling. That is what you have come for — Maha Shivratri. I will ask anyone: what is the Shivling a symbol of? Has anyone ever read the Shiva Purana or the Linga Purana?"

In this chapter we will understand, in Acharya Ji's own words, the symbolic meaning of the Shivling, the bilva leaf, the family of Shiva and the word "Shiva" itself, and see which things within ourselves they point to.

1. How Did the Formless Take a Form?

Acharya Ji explains that people of other religions often question the worship of the Shivling:

"People of other religions ask, 'Are you worshipping parts of the body like this?' That is exactly what they ask, and they laugh about it too."

In reply, someone says the Shivling is a symbol of the formless (**nirakar**). But that raises another question:

"The question is, how did the formless get a form? It does have some form, doesn't it? How did the formless get a form? So the answer is: our own people do not know their own scriptures, that is why this happens."

According to Acharya Ji, the problem is not the question but our ignorance of our own scriptures.

2. The Embodied Shiva and the Linga Sharira

Acharya Ji distinguishes between two forms of Shiva:

"There is the embodied (**sakar**) form of Shiva — with matted locks and all, with the Ganga flowing — that is called **sakar**. It is a symbol of our own body. And this Shivling that you see is called the **linga sharira**."

So the embodied form with matted locks and the Ganga symbolises our visible body, and the Shivling symbolises the **linga sharira**, which is not seen.

3. The Question of the Dead Body: Who Is

That Invisible Power?

To explain this invisible part, Acharya Ji gives a simple example. There are two people: one good, one bad.

"All your life you did good work, and he did bad work. After that, both of you died and were gone. Your body is lying here, and his body is lying here too. My question is: can your body do auspicious work now? Can his body do bad work? The answer is — no."

So the body by itself does neither good nor bad. Something else makes it act:

"So was there a power that could not be seen, which was making good work happen through me and something inauspicious happen through him? There was some invisible thing inside us, wasn't there? ... Otherwise, even after death it is the same body — ears, nose, hands, feet, everything was the same."

This is where Acharya Ji reveals the meaning of the Shivling:

"Something was there — the **jivatma**, the **jiva** — it is not seen. What was visible was the embodied thing; and the formless part within us, its symbol is what we call the Shivling."

The Shivling is a symbol of the formless **jiva** within us, without which the body can do nothing.

4. Aling: Beyond Purusha and Prakriti

Beyond even the Shivling is a state that has no symbol at all:

"And when we come to the total, complete formless — what is called Purushottam, beyond Purusha and Prakriti — its name in our scriptures is 'Aling'. It was never born at all — unborn (**ajanma**)."

Aling means that which has no **linga** (mark, symbol). Acharya Ji repeats:

"Perhaps we do not know our own scriptures properly, and that is why the problem arises. Many people of other religions come to me. I explain each of our symbols to them, one by one."

5. Three Bilva Leaves: The Offering of Three

A three-leaved bilva is offered on the Shivling. Acharya Ji asks: what are these three?

"What three did you offer? Sattva, rajas, tamas — these three gunas; going beyond all three gunas, **gunatrayatit.**"

Along with the three gunas, the three bodies as well:

"My three bodies — this physical body, the gross body (**sthula sharira**); the subtle body (**sukshma sharira**) — my mind, my prana, the energy body; and after that the causal body (**karana sharira**) — my **vijnanamaya kosha** and **anandamaya kosha** — going beyond even these. I offered all three of these three."

And the three times as well:

"The three times — present, past, future — going beyond all three, becoming **kalatit**, beyond time. ... Being **kalatit** means having no relationship with time, with the clock."

So offering the bilva leaf is an offering of three things:

- **The three gunas** — sattva, rajas, tamas → becoming **gunatrayatit**, beyond the gunas
- **The three bodies** — gross, subtle, causal → going beyond all three
- **The three times** — past, present, future → becoming **kalatit**, beyond time

6. Becoming Kalatit: The Missed Flight

Acharya Ji refers to the Gita:

"Shri Krishna has said in the Gita that those who are captured in time, stuck in it, will be reborn. Those who have gone beyond time have no worry about time."

But he immediately makes clear that going beyond time does not mean being careless:

"This does not mean whether you start the programme on time or not. Catching your aeroplane has to be on time. If you miss it, there should be no tension."

"Perhaps that plane was going to crash. Or perhaps it was not going to crash, poor thing, but you would have had some trouble after getting there. Fine, even if something happened, there would be some lesson. You missed this aeroplane, but the airport does not shut down. One who understands this slowly becomes *kalatit*."

Do your work on time, but do not get stuck worrying about time and results. That is the practice of going beyond time.

7. Beyond the Triputi

Another form of three is the **triputi** — the division into doer, action and object:

"Devotee, God, devotion — as long as we feel these three — I am a devotee, of someone; I am the one doing the worship; I am devotion — when we feel three like this, it is called the **triputi**."

"The seer, seen and seeing; knower, known and knowing; lover, beloved and love — as long as these feel like three separate things, there will be rebirth."

Offering the three leaves of the bilva is also an offering of this triputi. Acharya Ji says:

"We do not even know from our own scriptures what we were supposed to do. We have done plenty of ritual (**karmakand**). Now let us come to knowledge (**jnana**). And beyond knowledge, to its fruit (**phalashruti**)."

8. Shiva and Parvati: Purusha and Prakriti

Now Acharya Ji explains the meaning of Shiva and Parvati. Parvati is the daughter of the mountain, that is, a symbol of **inert matter (jada)**:

"Parvati — daughter of the mountain (**parvat**) — inert. Inert matter, all of our nature — mind, intellect, ego — that is called Prakriti, Mula Prakriti, primordial nature. Shiva Ji is called Purusha."

He explains the word "Purusha" through the metaphor of the body:

"This body of ours has been called a town. It is called a **pur**. ... This **pur**, which has nine gates — the ears, nose and so on. So the one who sleeps or dwells within such a **pur** — '**puri shete iti purushah**' — is called Purusha."

Puri shete iti purushah — the one who rests in the **pur** (the city of the body) is Purusha. And the meaning of the word "Prakriti":

"The first creation that happened in this is called the first creation (**pratham kriti**), meaning Prakriti, Mula Prakriti. That is Parvati, that daughter of the Himalaya — inert."

That is, Shiva is the consciousness dwelling within, and Parvati is the primordial nature from which mind, intellect and ego are made.

9. The Family of Shiva: Ganapati and Kartikeya

The other members of Shiva's family are also symbols of what is within us:

"After that, when I did the first act, the act of thinking — the work of thinking was Ganapati's. I will become the lord of the **ganas** only when I have discerning intellect (**vivek buddhi**)."

"In the same way Kartikeya — of what you call the family of Shiva — is the commander, meaning my body, the five senses and the mind; that is why he is called **Shadanan**."

- **Ganapati** — discerning intellect; lord of the **ganas**, the senses

- **Kartikeya (Shadanan, the six-faced)** — the commander; the five senses and the mind

10. Shiva: The Union of Purusha and Prakriti

Bringing all of this together, Acharya Ji gives the symbolic meaning of Shiva and the Shivling:

"Lord Shiva is the symbol of the union of Purusha and Prakriti, which I just explained to you. That is why in the Shivling too, it is a symbol of the male and the female — the **linga** and the **yoni** — of Prakriti."

So here is the answer to the question this chapter began with: the Shivling is **not the worship of a body part** but a symbol of the union of Purusha (consciousness) and Prakriti (matter) that exists within all of us.

11. "Shi" and "Va": The Feminine and Masculine Within

Both Shiva and Shakti are present in the word "Shiva" itself:

"The word Shiva is made of two parts — 'Shi' and 'Va'. 'Shi' indicates the feminine principle within you and represents the left side of your body."

"'Va' indicates the masculine principle within you and represents the right side of your body."

Acharya Ji offers a simple experiment to experience this yourself:

"Try it sometime — just say 'Shi', see what happens, see where its vibration comes. It should come in the right place. ... Try saying 'Va' as well."

"After that, Shiva, Shivaa — Shivaa means Parvati — and in its meaning, moksha and a great deal more is included."

12. The Many Meanings of Shiva: Auspicious and Healthy

Acharya Ji says that fifteen meanings of Shiva can be drawn out, and describes a few of them:

"Fifteen meanings of Shiva can be drawn out. One — all-pervading, the one in a state of bliss."

"The word Shiva — auspicious, meaning bringer of good fortune (**mangalkarak**); **kalyanprad**, the one who brings about your welfare."

"Second meaning — in good health, meaning **swasth** — being established in the Self (**swa**). That too is called Shiva."

Swasth does not merely mean free of disease, but **established in the Self**. To be established in one's true nature is to be Shiva.

Summary: Key Teachings

- 1 The Shivling is not the worship of a body part.** It is a symbol of the formless **jiva** within us, the **linga sharira**; the embodied Shiva with matted locks symbolises our visible body.
- 2 A dead body can do neither good nor bad.** The invisible power that made it act is the **jivatma**, and the Shivling is its symbol.
- 3 Purushottam is "Aling",** beyond both Purusha and Prakriti, unborn.
- 4 Three bilva leaves are an offering of three:** the three gunas (sattva, rajas, tamas), the three bodies (gross, subtle, causal) and the three times (past, present, future). The goal is to become **gunatrayatit** and **kalatit**.
- 5 Going beyond time does not mean carelessness.** Catch your flight on time, but if you miss it, no tension; "the airport does not shut down."
- 6 Going beyond the triputi:** as long as devotee-God-devotion, the seer-seen-seeing, lover-beloved-love feel separate, there is rebirth.

- 7 Shiva is Purusha, Parvati is Mula Prakriti. **Puri shete iti purushah**: the one dwelling in the nine-gated city of the body is Purusha.
- 8 Ganapati is discerning intellect; Kartikeya (Shadanan) is the commander, the five senses and the mind.
- 9 "Shi" is the feminine principle (left side), "Va" the masculine principle (right side). Both Shiva and Shakti are within the word Shiva.
- 10 Shiva means auspicious, welfare and **swasth**, that is, being established in the Self.